

U.S. Aircraft Combat Losses in Operation Epic Fury: Considerations for Congress

Updated October 5, 2026

Overview

On February 28, 2026, the United States, in coordination with Israel, initiated [military operations against Iran](#) initially under the designation Operation Epic Fury (OEF). The conflict has involved air, maritime, and missile combat engagements across the Middle East. The pace of combat activity declined amid a [ceasefire](#) in April. Within weeks, some strikes resumed, and conditions remain fluid.

The Department of Defense (DOD, which is “using a secondary Department of War designation,” under [Executive Order](#) 14347 dated September 5, 2025) on September 14, 2026, [published](#) a *Lead Inspector General (Lead IG) Report to the United States Congress on Operation Epic Fury (OEF)*, which assessed [certain equipment losses](#) relating to operations against Iran between April 1 and June 30. Some analysts and DOD officials have published varying estimates of the cost to replace lost equipment, including aircraft. In September 2026, the Congressional Budget Office (CBO) [estimated](#) the cost of equipment losses as of August 1 at between \$1.9 billion and \$3.3 billion, depending on DOD plans for replacements.

Listed below are 81 fixed-wing or rotary-wing aircraft, including uncrewed aircraft systems (UAS, or drones), reportedly lost or damaged in U.S. operations against Iran since February 28, according to news reports, statements by DOD and U.S. Central Command (CENTCOM), and the DOD Inspector General (DODIG, which was [designated](#) the Lead IG for OEF). The number of aircraft may remain subject to revision due to multiple factors, which may include classification, ongoing combat activity, and attribution. Some damaged aircraft may have been [returned](#) to active service.

Reports of Aircraft Losses and Damage

Twelve F-15E Strike Eagle fighter aircraft

- On March 2, 2026, CENTCOM [reported](#) three F-15Es destroyed by friendly fire over Kuwait.
- On April 5, 2026, CENTCOM [reported](#) one F-15E destroyed over Iran.

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- On [September 9-10, 2026](#), multiple articles reported that eight F-15s sustained light damage in an Iranian strike on Muwaffaq Salti Air Base, Jordan, and were returned to service.

One F-35A Lightning II fighter aircraft

- A March 19, 2026, article reported that Iranian ground fire damaged one F-35A over Iran.

Two A-10 Thunderbolt II ground-attack aircraft

- On April 6, 2026, Chairman of the Joint Chiefs of Staff Air Force General Dan Caine stated that enemy fire struck one A-10 that crashed and was destroyed.
- On [September 9-10, 2026](#), articles citing U.S. officials reported that one A-10 was severely damaged in an Iranian strike on Muwaffaq Salti Air Base, Jordan.

Seven KC-135 Stratotanker aerial refueling aircraft

- On March 12, 2026, CENTCOM [reported](#) that two KC-135s were involved in an incident; one aircraft crashed in Iraq, resulting in the deaths of all six aircrew. The second KC-135 made an emergency landing.
- A March 14, 2026, article reported that an Iranian attack damaged five KC-135s on the ground at Prince Sultan Air Base, Saudi Arabia.

One E-3 Sentry airborne early warning-and-control system aircraft

- A March 28, 2026, article reported that one E-3 was damaged at Prince Sultan Air Base. A [September 15, 2026](#), article reported that the plane experienced “a direct hit.”

Two MC-130J Commando II special operations aircraft

- An April 5, 2026, article reported that two MC-130Js supporting search-and-rescue operations for a downed F-15E were intentionally destroyed.

One HH-60W Jolly Green II combat search-and-rescue helicopter

- On April 6, 2026, General Caine said in a press conference that one HH-60W sustained damage during search-and-rescue operations for a downed F-15E in Iran.

One MQ-4C Triton high-altitude long-endurance uncrewed aircraft

- An April 14, 2026, article citing a U.S. Navy document reported that one MQ-4C crashed in a mishap.

Three MQ-1 multi-role uncrewed aircraft

- On [May 31, 2026](#), CENTCOM reported that Iran had shot down a “U.S. MQ-1 drone.”
- A [September 17, 2026](#), article citing U.S. officials stated that Iran had “in recent days” downed “at least two ... MQ-1” aircraft.

Forty-five MQ-9 Reaper multi-role uncrewed aircraft

- An August 13, 2026, article citing three U.S. officials reported that the U.S. military had lost “at least 45” [MQ-9 Reapers](#) in operations against Iran.

One AH-64 Apache attack helicopter

- On [September 14, 2026](#), the Lead IG reported that one AH-64 helicopter had been shot down over the Strait of Hormuz.

Four AH-6 Little Bird light attack helicopters

- On [September 14, 2026](#), the Lead IG reported that U.S. forces had destroyed four AH-6 helicopters during rescue operations.

One MH-60 Sea Hawk maritime helicopter

- On [September 14, 2026](#), the Lead IG reported that one MH-60 helicopter crashed over the Arabian Sea.

Potential Issues for Congress

These reported incidents may raise several considerations for congressional oversight:

- **Information available to Congress.** Congress may assess whether or not it has sufficient information and time to evaluate the potential effects of aircraft damage and losses in U.S. military operations and potential DOD plans or programs to acquire replacements.
- **Budgetary impacts.** Members of Congress may consider whether or not to approve, reject, or modify requests for funding relating to the replacement or repair of aircraft lost or damaged in OEF.
- **Force sufficiency.** Congress may assess whether losses in certain high-demand platforms that are aging and limited in number, such as the E-3 Sentry, create capability gaps or increase risk in other theaters.
- **Industrial base capacity.** Congress may assess whether current production lines and supply chains can replace lost aircraft within time frames needed to meet DOD operational requirements. Congress may seek information about the extent to which competing demands—including foreign military sales or production constraints—may affect DOD’s ability to regenerate capacity.
- **Operational risk.** Congress may assess whether reported losses reflect changes in the threat environment or in adversary capabilities. Congress may also assess whether any changes to the threat might signal the need to [adjust](#) U.S. equipment; operational concepts; tactics, techniques, and procedures; or basing posture.

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